

and never got a bid on any of it. A stock like that just slides from 4 to 3 to 1 and finally disappears altogether, and there's nothing you can do about it. It doesn't kill you as long as you don't do it too often, like a lot of other things. But at times I am reminded of the galley slaves in *Ben-Hur*, who are chained to their seats while the ship is sinking.

There's one sure antidote to the liquidity problem: buy stocks you believe you'll hold on to for a good long time. And I mean years, by which time, if all's gone as hoped, the company will be bigger, many more analysts and investors will be interested in it, and liquidity will be far less of a worry. More important, you'll still have a hefty profit to comfort you if you have to sacrifice a bit of your gain to get out of a position.